

RASNA

Authentic Small-Group Travel Experiences in Blera, Northern Lazio (Tuscia)

Business Plan & Financial Projections

Project Overview

Founders: Maria Grazia (local operations & relationships) and Nikolai Fissenko (international markets, marketing & logistics)

Location: Blera, Province of Viterbo, Lazio, Italy

1. Executive Summary

Rasna offers small-group, multi-day immersive travel experiences in and around Blera, a small town in the Tuscia region of northern Lazio. Rather than a conventional sightseeing tour, guests participate directly in the real, seasonal life of the community: harvesting olives, helping make the year's tomato sauce, working alongside local artisans, and eating meals prepared in the tradition of local families — supported by guided excursions to nearby Etruscan sites, lakes, villas and towns (Lago di Vico, Villa Lante, Tarquinia, Viterbo).

The business is deliberately positioned at the premium end of the niche cultural-immersion travel market (€1,300–€1,800 per guest for a 4-day/3-night all-inclusive package, launching at €1,400). It is asset-light: lodging is sourced through partner B&Bs, activities are hosted by local families and artisans who are paid fairly for their time, and the founders act as curators, guides and operators.

Growth is intentionally capped at roughly 15–20 small groups per year once mature. This is a deliberate strategic choice, not a constraint: the product's core value — an unspoiled, authentic, low-volume experience — would be destroyed by mass tourism. Income growth beyond this point comes from premium pricing, higher-value add-ons and multi-region itineraries, not from increasing visitor volume to the town.

Key figures at maturity (Year 3+, ~16 groups/year):

Metric	Value
Average group size	8 guests
Price per guest	€1,400 (range €1,300–€1,800)
Cost per guest	~€720
Gross margin per guest	~€680 (~49%)
Gross profit per group	~€5,440
Annual revenue (16 groups)	~€179,200
Annual gross profit (16 groups)	~€87,000
Estimated startup investment	~€4,500–€11,500
Estimated break-even	~2 successful groups

2. The Opportunity

2.1 The product

A 4-day / 3-night, all-inclusive small-group package combining: one anchor seasonal/agricultural activity, one or more artisan experiences, guided cultural and nature excursions in the surrounding Tuscia region, lodging at partner B&Bs, and meals prepared in the tradition of local families.

2.2 Why Blera, why now

- International demand for “authentic Italy” beyond Rome/Florence/Tuscany is well established and growing — comparable ultra-niche culinary/cultural immersion trips run €1,000–€2,500+ per person.
- Blera and the surrounding Tuscia region offer genuine, still-living agricultural traditions (olive harvest, tomato sauce day, hazelnut and artichoke harvests, asparagus foraging) and significant unexploited cultural assets (Etruscan rock-cut tombs, Via Clodia, Lago di Vico, Villa Lante, Tarquinia, Viterbo).

- The town already hosts a calendar of community festivals (Corpus Domini, summer sagre, the Cantine Festival in November) that provide ready-made, atmospheric moments to build departures around.
- No competing operator currently offers this kind of deeply local, small-group, all-inclusive experience centred on Blera.

2.3 Target customers

- English-speaking travelers (US, UK, Australia, Canada) seeking authentic, off-the-beaten-path Italian experiences.
- Couples, friend groups, food-and-culture travelers; potential B2B channels include culinary schools, niche travel agencies and corporate retreats booking exclusive departures.
- Price-sensitive to value, not headline price — guests are paying for access, scarcity and story.

2.4 Differentiation & defensibility

- Most operators sell sights; Rasna sells belonging and participation — this is difficult to replicate without genuine, long-standing local relationships.
- Two-founder fit: Maria Grazia brings local relationships, access to families/farms/artisans and community credibility; the international co-founder brings marketing, logistics and English-speaking guest management.
- Asset-light model: no property ownership required at launch — lodging via partner B&Bs, activities via paid local hosts and artisans.

3. The Experience — Activities & Calendar

The activity calendar has been built and validated through direct, ongoing conversations with local contacts in Blera (see Section 7, Local Network). It is treated as a menu of possibilities to validate one experience at a time, prioritizing reliability and authenticity over a fully pre-packaged 12-month programme.

3.1 Confirmed launch program

Activity	Status / notes
Olive harvest (Oct–Dec)	Reliable, real agricultural activity — one of the strongest seasonal anchors
Tomato harvest / “sauce day” (Aug)	Confirmed reliably available; strong low-risk anchor for an August departure
Cured meats / affettati (Emiliano)	Artisan demonstration with tasting; year-round availability to be confirmed directly with host
Leatherwork / bag-making (Renzo)	High availability; hands-on session where guests make and keep their own item — strong, marketable activity, potentially offered at little/no hosting cost as guests purchase his goods afterward
Horseback riding (Maneggio Civitella Cesi)	Candidate complementary excursion; availability and group handling to be assessed

3.2 Year-round calendar of candidate activities

The following seasonal activities represent the longer-term ambition for a full annual calendar, to be validated and added one at a time as hosts are confirmed:

Period	Activity
March–June	Wild asparagus foraging in the Tuscia woods; spring planting
January–February	Traditional pig butchering and curing (narrow window, host availability to be validated)
July–August	Tomato harvest and “sauce day” (passata) — confirmed
Late August–September	Hazelnut harvest — the Tuscia produces ~40% of Italy's national output
September–October	Vendemmia (grape harvest) — framed as “a day of harvest”; cellar visits via the Cantine Festival
October–December	Olive harvest and oil pressing — confirmed, reliable anchor
December	Italian Christmas traditions — food, customs and family rituals
January–May	Artichoke harvest (Carciofo Romanesco IGP) and seasonal cooking

3.3 Cooking experiences

Meals are framed as “cooking in the tradition of the nonne” — a field lunch or panonto prepared in the traditional style by a local host — rather than promising a specific individual. This keeps the experience authentic while being sustainable and not dependent on any one person's long-term availability. Compliance: as soon as cooking for paying guests becomes part of a recurring commercial package, Italian food-safety/home-restaurant rules apply. The plan is either to keep this activity structured as an occasional “meal with a local family” within the relevant agriturismo/cesarine-style framework, or to channel it through an already-licensed venue/partner kitchen — to be finalized with a local commercialista before scaling.

3.4 Local festivals as built-in marketing moments

- June — Corpus Domini celebrations
- Summer (most weekends) — local sagre (food and folk festivals)
- Second weekend of November — the Cantine Festival, when local wine cellars open to the public

These events require no additional management — they are existing community moments that make certain departure dates especially compelling and easy to market.

4. Business Model

- Sell fixed-departure or on-demand small-group packages of 6–10 guests (target average 8) over 4 days / 3 nights.
- Package includes: lodging via partner B&Bs, all meals, local guiding/transport, and all activity/artisan fees — priced as a single all-inclusive fee so guests have no logistics to manage.
- Revenue comes from the per-guest package price; costs are largely variable (lodging, hosting fees, transport, activities, insurance), keeping the model asset-light and scalable without major fixed-cost investment.
- Optional upsell: multi-region itineraries combining Blera with Rome, Lago di Vico, Villa Lante, Tarquinia or the coast.

5. Financial Plan

5.1 Pricing

Recommended launch price: **€1,400 per guest, all-inclusive** (4 days / 3 nights), within a target range of €1,300–€1,800 reflecting comparable ultra-niche Italian culinary/cultural immersion products. Pricing is positioned at the premium end deliberately: the product is “one of very few groups admitted this year,” not a budget tour.

5.2 Per-guest cost structure

Cost item	Estimate (€)
Lodging (3 nights, partner B&B rate)	170
Meals & local hosting fees (fair pay for hosts)	220
Local guiding/transport (incl. day trips)	140
Activity fees (olive picking, artisan sessions, equipment)	90
Guest activity insurance (hands-on activities)	40
Marketing & booking overhead (allocated)	60
Total cost per guest	~720

Gross margin per guest: ~€680 (~49%). Hosting fees and insurance are built into the cost model from the outset based on direct local feedback — this is treated as real, paid work, not a favor economy, and insurance for manual/hands-on activities (harvesting, leatherwork, etc.) is considered a non-negotiable cost.

5.3 Local transport rates (quoted, Maria Grazia)

Service	Rate
Transfer Fiumicino ↔ Blera, 7-pax Mercedes minivan	€220.00 + IVA 10%
Guided tour Blera/Tarquinia	€50.00/hour + IVA 10% (100 km included)

These quotes are used to refine the local guiding/transport line above and to price an optional Fiumicino airport transfer add-on.

5.4 Group economics

Assuming an average group size of 8 guests:

Item	Value
Revenue per group (8 × €1,400)	€11,200
Cost per group (8 × €720)	€5,760
Gross profit per group	~€5,440

5.5 Revenue projections (deliberately capped growth)

Year	Groups/year	Revenue	Gross profit	Notes
Year 1 — Pilot & launch	4	~€44,800	~€21,800	1 pilot (discounted/break-even) + 3–4 paying groups

Year 2 — Established calendar	8	~€89,600	~€43,500	4–5 experiences across the seasonal calendar, ~1 group every 4–6 weeks
Year 3+ — Mature steady state	16	~€179,200	~€87,000	Deliberate ceiling of ~15–20 groups/year, chosen to protect the destination

These figures are directional planning estimates. They intentionally plateau rather than grow indefinitely — beyond Year 3, growth is expected to come from the levers described in Section 5.8, not from increasing the number of groups.

5.6 Startup investment required

Item	Estimated cost (€)
Legal setup (Italian business entity + commercialista)	1,500–3,000
Licensing & insurance (tourism, food handling)	500–1,500
Website & branding	500–2,000
Pilot trip costs (discounted/break-even run)	1,000–2,000
Group transport (van purchase/lease, or hired locally)	0–15,000
Marketing launch (photos, video, ads)	1,000–3,000
Total estimated startup investment	~4,500–11,500

Transport is initially planned as a per-group variable cost (hired locally) rather than a fixed asset, given the deliberately limited number of trips per year (~15–20). Vehicle purchase will be revisited in Year 2–3 once real per-group transport costs are established.

5.7 Break-even

At ~€5,440 gross profit per group, a ~€10,000 startup investment is recovered after approximately **2 successful groups** — realistically achievable within Year 1.

5.8 Revenue growth levers beyond the capacity ceiling

- Premium pricing over time: raise price from €1,400 toward €1,800+ as reputation and demand build.
- Premium add-ons: private/extended stays, exclusive harvest- or Christmas-only departures with smaller groups and higher prices.
- Multi-region itineraries: combine Blera with Rome, Lago di Vico, Villa Lante, Tarquinia or the coast for longer, higher-value packages.
- Pure-margin extras with zero additional footfall: virtual experiences (online cooking sessions) and merchandise (olive oil, wine, hazelnuts, sauces from partner families) sold to past guests.
- B2B / high-value bookings: culinary schools, travel agencies or corporate retreats booking an entire exclusive departure at a premium rate.
- Brand equity: a strong reputation allows the founders to be selective about guests and partners, reinforcing both quality and price power.

6. Implementation Roadmap

Phase	Timeline	Key activities
0 — Partnership alignment	Immediate	Define roles, decision-making and profit/cost split between founders in writing
1 — Validate & design the offer	1–2 months	Confirm hosts and pricing for each candidate activity; design a detailed pilot itinerary; obtain insurance quotes; set pilot pricing
2 — Run a pilot group	2–4 months	Run a small real/discounted group; document everything (photos, video, testimonials); debrief and refine
3 — Build presence & first paying customers	Parallel with Phase 2	Launch website/landing page, booking process, and 1–2 marketing channels; convert pilot momentum into 1–3 paying groups
4 — Formalize the business	Once bookings exist	Choose Italian legal structure (e.g. SRL) with a local commercialista; finalize licensing/insurance; formalize partner agreements
5 — Build out the seasonal calendar	6–12 months	Add second/third seasonal experiences; build operational checklists; develop a bench of trained local hosts
6 — Mature at a deliberate ceiling	12+ months	Settle into ~15–20 groups/year; grow income via pricing and add-ons rather than volume; prioritize fit over scale

7. Local Network & Partnerships

A core strength of Rasna is that it is built from real, existing relationships in Blera rather than designed first and staffed later. Key contacts identified and engaged to date:

Contact	Role in the project
Maria Grazia	Co-founder — local relationships, operations, community credibility
Cristina Damiani	Operational coordination (role to be finalized)
Emiliano (Miriam's son)	Cured meats / affettati artisan experience
Renzo	Leatherwork / bag-making artisan experience
Maneggio Civitella Cesi	Horseback riding excursion (candidate)
Local B&Bs (Beccone, Antonella, others)	Lodging partners
La Torretta, Bar Etruria	Possible food/beverage and gathering-place partners

8. Key Risks & Mitigations

Risk	Mitigation
Some traditional activities (vendemmia, hand-harvesting wheat, pig butchering) are no longer practiced at scale	Calendar treated as a menu to validate one activity at a time; only confirmed, available activities are launched on
Dependence on a single host for any given experience (e.g., a cheesemaker, an elderly cook)	Frame experiences generically (“in the tradition of the nonne”) and build a bench of alternative hosts before scaling
Regulatory/food-safety requirements for paid home cooking experiences	Resolve with a local commercialista in Phase 4, via either a registered home-restaurant framework or a licensed partner kitchen

Guest injury during hands-on activities	Dedicated guest activity insurance is built into the per-guest cost from the outset
Demand risk / unproven willingness to pay at target price	Pilot group (Phase 2) validates pricing and demand before committing to marketing spend or formal structure
Over-growth eroding the authenticity that drives demand	Hard cap of ~15–20 groups/year is a deliberate strategic choice, with growth levers focused on price and value rather than volume

9. Summary

Rasna is a low-capital, asset-light business with a clear path to profitability: an estimated startup investment of **€4,500–€11,500**, a break-even point after roughly two successful group departures, and an estimated **~€87,000/year** in gross profit at a deliberately capped, mature scale of ~16 groups/year.

The founders welcome the opportunity to discuss this plan further and to share updated, validated figures following the Phase 1–2 pilot.